Topic Card Answer Key

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These are model answers for the topic card, one card per motion, both sides. Use them to check students' cards or to help a student who is stuck. Students should still write the cards in their own words.

Where the answers come from: Arguments 1 and 2, their examples, and the clash questions come from the books' Day 1 and Day 2 pages. The third argument comes from the books' rebuttals where possible. The "Even if" answers and POI questions are suggested models, not from the books.

1. Rent freezes (January)

Motion: THBT rent freezes are a form of harmful populism.

Key words: *rent freeze* — a rule that stops rent from going up for a time · *populism* — a policy that sounds good now but causes problems later · *landlord* — a person who rents out a home · *tenant* — a person who rents a home

Part	Proposition	Opposition
Motion in my own words	Stopping rent from rising sounds kind, but it causes bigger housing problems later.	Rent freezes are a fair way to protect renters when housing costs rise too fast.
Argument 1: Claim	Rent freezes distort the housing market.	Rent freezes keep the economy stable.
Argument 1: Because… so…	Landlords earn less, so some stop renting their homes or stop fixing them. So there are fewer homes to rent, and rent jumps later.	When rent stays the same, families have money left over. So they spend more at local shops and businesses.
Argument 1: For example…	Berlin's 2019 rent freeze helped some renters for a short time, but then caused housing shortages and fast rent increases.	Barcelona's rent freeze stopped housing costs from rising too fast and helped the local economy.

Part	Proposition	Opposition
Argument 1: This matters because…	In the long run, everyone looking for a home pays more and has fewer choices.	It protects many families and the whole local economy at once.
Argument 2: Claim	Rent freezes are unfair to new renters.	Rent freezes protect vulnerable people.
Argument 2: Because… so…	Only people who already rent are protected. Fewer homes come onto the market, so newcomers pay more.	Without rules, rent can rise faster than income. A freeze gives poor and young people time and safety.
Argument 2: For example…	In Barcelona, current renters were helped, but new renters had fewer homes and paid more.	In Vienna, strong rent rules and public housing help people find homes at lower prices.
Argument 2: This matters because…	Young people and newlyweds lose out, so inequality between generations grows.	People with different incomes can live together, which makes society more united.
Third argument (deputy)	Governments then spend on public housing or subsidies, which can raise taxes and cause money problems.	(Suggested) Families can stay in their homes, so children don't have to change schools and neighbourhoods stay together.
"Even if…" answer	Even if a freeze helps some renters today, it shrinks the number of homes, so the vulnerable people who need a home tomorrow lose.	Even if some landlords leave, a freeze stops people losing their homes right now, and the government can add housing, as Vienna does.
2 POI questions	"If landlords earn less, why would they keep renting out their homes?" · "How does a freeze help a young couple looking for their first home?"	"Should families lose their homes while we wait for the market to fix itself?" · "Vienna has strong rent rules and affordable housing. How does that fit your argument?"

Clash 1: Do rent freezes hurt or help the housing market? **Clash 2:** Who is protected, and who is left out?

2. Humanoid robots like Atlas (March)

Motion: THBT humanoid robots like Atlas must be restricted from fully replacing humans in automobile factories.

Key words: *humanoid* — a robot shaped like a human · *be restricted* — be limited by rules or laws · *automation* — using machines to do work automatically · *unemployment* — not having a job while wanting to work · *productivity* — how much is produced

Part	Proposition	Opposition
Motion in my own words	Car companies should not be allowed to replace all their human workers with robots. We need limits.	Companies should be free to use robots like Atlas. Limits would hurt progress.
Argument 1: Claim	Mass job loss hurts social stability.	Robots make work safer and help society move forward.
Argument 1: Because… so…	Many workers can lose their jobs at once, and they cannot retrain quickly. So inequality grows and local towns decline.	Robots take dangerous, repetitive tasks. So workers move to safer jobs like checking and managing.
Argument 1: For example…	After Amazon warehouses automated, many low-skill workers lost jobs and only a few moved into technical roles.	In Tesla factories, workers moved from risky assembly work to checking and managing roles. Computers created new IT jobs at companies like Microsoft.
Argument 1: This matters because…	Thousands of families and whole towns depend on factory jobs.	Fewer workers get hurt, and technology creates new, better jobs.
Argument 2: Claim	The economy needs people who can buy things.	Robots make companies more productive and competitive.
Argument 2: Because… so…	People without jobs spend less, so companies sell less. Welfare costs rise, and big companies push small ones out.	Robots lower costs, so prices fall and demand rises. Without robots, companies fall behind in global competition.

Part	Proposition	Opposition
Argument 2: For example…	After Foxconn automated, there were big layoffs and local business fell. GM's layoffs weakened middle-class towns.	BMW raised productivity and used tax money to train workers. Flexible rules helped Toss grow quickly.
Argument 2: This matters because…	Short-term efficiency can make the whole economy weaker in the long run.	Companies and jobs survive against foreign competitors, and new industries like robotics and AI appear.
Third argument (deputy)	Humanoid robots replace workers too fast. Training takes time, but job loss happens right away.	Robots are not the only cause of unemployment. Governments and companies share the duty to retrain workers.
"Even if…" answer	Even if new jobs appear later, workers lose their jobs today. Limits only slow the change so people have time to train.	Even if some workers lose jobs, the answer is training and support. Restricting robots could make the whole company lose to foreign rivals and cost every job.
2 POI questions	"Can a 50-year-old factory worker become a robot engineer in one year?" · "Who will buy cars if factory workers lose their income?"	"If foreign factories use robots and ours don't, what happens to our jobs?" · "Shouldn't we fix job loss with training instead of blocking technology?"

Clash 1: Does fast automation break society or move it forward? **Clash 2:** Which matters more for growth, efficiency or customers who can buy?

3. Excess profits to workers (July)

Motion: THBT companies' excess profits should be distributed to workers before shareholders.

Key words: *excess profits* — profits bigger than expected · *distribute* — give out to several people or groups · *shareholder* — a person who owns shares in a company · *bonus* — extra pay for good results · *investment* — money put in to earn more later

Part	Proposition	Opposition
Motion in my own words	When a company makes extra profit, the workers who made it should get their share first.	Shareholders should get extra profit first, because they took the financial risk.
Argument 1: Claim	Workers deserve a fair reward for their labor.	Fairness means rewarding investment risk.
Argument 1: Because… so…	Workers make the products and keep the company running every day. So they helped create the extra profit.	Shareholders give the company money for factories, products and workers. If the company fails, they can lose that money.
Argument 1: For example…	In 2026, Samsung Electronics agreed with its union on performance bonuses, recognizing workers' contribution.	Without shareholders' investment, Samsung could not build its chip factories or hire workers.
Argument 1: This matters because…	Many workers live on their wages, while shareholders often already have money, so sharing reduces the gap.	If risk is not rewarded, fewer people will invest, and fewer companies can start or grow.
Argument 2: Claim	Sharing profits increases spending and productivity.	Giving workers profits first reduces investment and growth.
Argument 2: Because… so…	Workers spend extra money on food, housing and education, so money returns to the market. Rewarded workers are more motivated and loyal.	If shareholders get less, investors move their money elsewhere. Big bonuses are also hard to cut later, even in bad times.
Argument 2: For example…	Profit-sharing systems and employee stock ownership plans (ESOPs) make workers care more about the company. Efficiency wage theory says better rewards raise productivity.	Samsung needed huge investment in chip facilities, research and AI-based factories at the same time as the bonus debate.
Argument 2: This matters because…	Both the economy and the company benefit, so it's an investment, not just a cost.	Less money for research and new technology means fewer future jobs.

Part	Proposition	Opposition
Third argument (deputy)	If profits go only to shareholders, the gap between rich asset owners and workers gets bigger.	It creates new inequality among workers. Big-company workers gain, while subcontractors and temporary workers are left out (Samsung's non-chip workers were excluded).
"Even if…" answer	Even if shareholders took a risk, they already own the company and gain when its value rises. Workers only have their wages, so they should share in profits they made.	Even if bonuses boost spending for a while, a company that stops investing loses to competitors and cuts jobs later.
2 POI questions	"Without workers, could shareholders' money make a single product?" · "Why should the people who did the work be last in line?"	"If the company loses money next year, will workers give back their bonuses?" · "What about subcontractors who don't get these bonuses?"

Clash 1: Who deserves the reward, workers or shareholders? **Clash 2:** Does sharing profits grow or shrink the company in the long run?

4. Going public to grow (August)

Motion: THBT companies should become public companies when they want to grow.

Key words: *public company* — a company listed on the stock market · *private company* — a company owned by its founders and a few investors · *share* — a small part of a company that people can buy · *IPO* — when a company first sells shares to the public · *investor* — a person who puts money into a company

Part	Proposition	Opposition
Motion in my own words	A company that wants to grow big should sell its shares on the stock market.	Companies can grow just as well, or better, by staying private.
Argument 1: Claim	Going public gives companies more money.	Companies can grow without going public.

Part	Proposition	Opposition
Argument 1: Because… so…	Many people can buy shares, so the company gets a lot of money. Unlike a bank loan, it doesn't have to be paid back with interest.	Companies can get money from private investors or banks. So the founder keeps more control.
Argument 1: For example…	Amazon went public in 1997 and used the money to grow from an online bookstore into a global company.	SpaceX did much of its big growth while it was private, funded by private investors.
Argument 1: This matters because…	Growth needs money for factories, technology and workers.	Founders can follow their long-term vision without outside pressure.
Argument 2: Claim	Going public makes companies more careful.	Private companies can make faster and bolder decisions.
Argument 2: Because… so…	Public companies must share important information, and a group of people checks big decisions. So one founder can't make careless choices alone.	Public companies are checked by the stock market every three months, so managers worry about quick results. Private companies can take long-term risks.
Argument 2: For example…	After going public in 2012, Meta followed public company rules, kept growing, bought WhatsApp in 2014 and invested in AI.	SpaceX had many rocket test failures but kept trying, and built reusable rockets and Starlink.
Argument 2: This matters because…	It protects investors and workers from risky, careless decisions.	Big, world-changing ideas often fail at first and need patience.
Third argument (deputy)	Private money may not be enough. Private investors don't fund every company, and very large growth needs many investors.	Money from shares is not free. Going public costs a lot, brings many rules, and makes the company worry about its stock price.

Part	Proposition	Opposition
"Even if…" answer	Even if private companies can be bolder, most companies can't raise enough private money, and public checks stop bold decisions from becoming reckless ones.	Even if going public brings more money, the founder loses control and the company chases short-term stock prices, which can kill the bold projects that make it grow.
2 POI questions	"How many companies are as famous as SpaceX, so private investors will fund them?" · "Who stops a private founder from making a careless decision?"	"If the stock price drops after one failed project, will managers dare to try again?" · "Why does the founder have to give up control just to grow?"

Clash 1: Is going public the best way to get money for growth? **Clash 2:** Does stock market pressure make decisions better or worse?

5. Equality vs. equity (September)

Motion: THBT treating everyone the same cannot achieve true equality.

Key words: *equality* — the same rules and resources for everyone · *equity* — different support based on each person's needs · *treat* — behave toward someone in a certain way · *achieve* — reach a goal through effort · *reverse discrimination* — unfair treatment of people who are not in a supported group

This is a **principle** motion: argue about fairness, dignity and rights, not money.

Part	Proposition	Opposition
Motion in my own words	Giving everyone exactly the same treatment isn't truly fair, because people start from different places.	The same rules for everyone are the fairest system. Special treatment creates new unfairness.
Argument 1: Claim	Treating everyone the same keeps existing inequality.	It is hard to set clear rules for who needs help.
Argument 1: Because… so…	Rich students get private education, consulting and better information. So even with the same rules, results stay unequal.	People's lives depend on many things, but public systems must use simple categories. So some people who really need help are left out.

Part	Proposition	Opposition
Argument 1: For example…	Seoul students had about 2.6 times the admission rate to Seoul National University, and about 92% of the gap was linked to family money and private education.	Korea's Basic Pension Act excludes some retired public officials, even some with very low incomes, just because of their category.
Argument 1: This matters because…	Social gaps continue from one generation to the next.	Equity can create welfare blind spots and new unfairness.
Argument 2: Claim	Equity protects dignity and real freedom of choice.	Equity can cause reverse discrimination.
Argument 2: Because… so…	People have different needs. Without extra support, some people have the same rights on paper but not the same real chance.	People should be judged by ability and effort. Group-based help can make someone lose a chance just because of the group they belong to.
Argument 2: For example…	Visually impaired students take the same CSAT but get 1.7 times more time and can use Braille or voice-support devices.	In 2023, the U.S. Supreme Court ruled against race-conscious admissions at Harvard and the University of North Carolina.
Argument 2: This matters because…	People with disabilities and others facing barriers can take part fully and independently.	Hard-working individuals feel unfairly treated, which creates tension in society.
Third argument (deputy)	Giving everyone the same support wastes resources and fails people with greater needs. The answer is to improve the rules, not give up equity.	Equal basic rights already protect dignity. Labeling people as disadvantaged can create stigma and make them depend on help.
"Even if…" answer	Even if some people feel left out, ignoring unequal starting points is a bigger unfairness, and well-designed policies still reward ability and effort.	Even if people start differently, help based on groups reaches the wrong people and misses others. Fair rules that judge each person individually are better.

Part	Proposition	Opposition
2 POI questions	"Is it fair to give a blind student the same test paper and time as everyone else?" · "If a student never had private tutoring, did they really have an equal chance?"	"How does the government decide who is disadvantaged enough?" · "Is it fair if a hard-working student loses a place because of the group they belong to?"

Clash 1: Do the same rules hide unequal starting points? **Clash 2:** Is different treatment fair, or a new kind of unfairness?